User Guide & Everyday Playbook

How to run a value study end-to-end — from a fresh problem to proven, realized value.

> **A polished, shareable version of this guide** (with a contents rail and light/dark theme) is published as an artifact — ask the maintainer for the link. This Markdown copy is the versioned reference.

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1 · What this platform is

One workspace that carries a piece of work through its **whole value lifecycle** — from a value engineer framing a problem and building the business case, to a value realization manager implementing it and proving the money was actually saved.

It maps to three complementary roles and their structured methods. The links are the point of the tool: every realization effort traces straight back to the study it came from, and every customer relationship references the studies and tracks beneath it — nothing gets lost between the hand-offs.

Role	What they do
🔵 **Value Engineer**	Runs the 8-phase VE Job Plan: analyse functions, cost and performance, generate and score alternatives, and produce a quantified business case with baselines, KPIs and success criteria.
🟢 **Value Realization Manager**	Runs the 7-phase realization lifecycle: implement approved recommendations, drive adoption, measure actuals against baseline, report to executives, and confirm realized value.
🔷 **Customer Success Manager**	Runs the continuous 8-stage engagement per account: onboarding, adoption, health, governance, renewal and expansion — referencing (not duplicating) the account's studies and tracks.

> **The vocabulary.** A **Value Lifecycle** = one **VE study** plus the **Value Realization track(s)** it spawns. "Starting a new lifecycle" means creating a study and running it through to a handover. Section 3 walks the whole thing.

2 · Signing in & who does what

Open the app and you land on the sign-in page. Enter your email and password, or use a **demo quick-login** button to jump in as a specific role. To experience the separation of duties, sign out and sign back in as a different person — the navigation and the buttons you see change with your role.

> **Demo logins.** Demo accounts are seeded with a shared password (set in `prisma/seed.ts`); rotate it in production. Try `ve@demo.app` (Value Engineer), `vrm@demo.app` (Realization Manager), `cs@demo.app` (Customer Success Manager), `reviewer@demo.app` (approver) and `viewer@demo.app` (read-only stakeholder).

Creating your own workspace

For real use, click **"Create a workspace"** on the sign-in page. You provide a workspace name, your name, email and password — this creates a **new, isolated organization** and makes you its **Administrator**. Your studies and tracks are private to your workspace.

As an admin, a **Team** link appears in the top nav. From there you **add teammates** (name, email, role, and an initial password to share), **change roles**, **reset passwords**, and **remove access**. Assign each person a role — Value Engineer, Value Realization Manager, Reviewer, or Viewer — and they get exactly the permissions in the table below.

Permissions are role-based — the platform enforces a real separation between the person who *builds* a case, the person who *approves* it, and the person who *realizes* it.

Capability	Value Engineer	Realization Mgr	Reviewer	Viewer
Create & edit studies, functions, alternatives, business case	✅	—	—	—
Accept / reject recommendations	—	—	✅	—
Create the realization track (handover)	✅	✅	—	—
Manage work packages, adoption, track status	—	✅	—	—
Record KPI actuals & realized benefits, publish reports	—	✅	—	—
Comment on studies & tracks	✅	✅	✅	✅
View everything & export documents	✅	✅	✅	✅

Admin can do all of the above. Everyone can read the portfolio, KPI dashboards and template library.

3 · Start a new Value Lifecycle

This is the everyday operating procedure. A study moves through the VE Job Plan, hits the handover, and continues through the realization lifecycle. Work each phase in order and use its guidance panel — purpose, key questions, tasks and **exit criteria** — as your checklist before advancing.

> **Follow-along scenario.** Your firm is asked to **cut the cost of a wastewater clarifier** without hurting treatment performance. The seeded demo study `VE-2026-014` is exactly this — sign in as the Value Engineer and follow the steps against it, or create your own fresh study and mirror them.

🔵 Value Engineering — building the case

1. Create the study — Go to **Value Engineering** and click **"New VE study"**. Give it a title, pick the **industry profile** (Construction, Manufacturing or SaaS — this tailors the study types, cost drivers, value levers and default KPIs), choose the **study type** and **currency** (defaults to ZAR), and write a one-line **problem statement**. → *Result:* a study with all 8 VE phases created and ready, and its own code (e.g. `VE-2026-021`).

2. Orientation & Information (phases 1–2) — Open the study. The phase stepper runs across the top; click a phase to load its guidance. In **Orientation** confirm scope, stakeholders and the target outcome; in **Information** assemble the cost and performance facts. Click **Start phase**, then **Mark complete** once the exit criteria are met. → *Tip:* the exit-criteria checklist is your quality gate — don't advance until it's genuinely satisfied.

3. Function analysis + FAST diagram (phase 3) — In the **Function model**, add each function as a **verb + noun** ("Separate solids"), classify it *basic* or *secondary*, and enter its **cost** and **worth**. The **value index** (cost ÷ worth) computes automatically and turns amber when a function costs far more than it's worth — that's where the savings hide. Set each function's "supports" link to build the how/why chain, and the **FAST diagram** renders it as a logic tree.

4. Generate alternatives — Creative (phase 4) — Under **Creative alternatives**, brainstorm ways to deliver each high-priority function. Use **"+ Add alternative"** to type your own, or **"✨ Brainstorm with AI"** to generate a spread of ideas instantly. Link each idea to the function it improves and **shortlist** the promising ones. → *AI note:* with an Anthropic API key configured the button drafts with Claude; without one it seeds ideas from the industry profile's value levers and reads **"Brainstorm (template)"**. Either way you get editable starter ideas.

5. Score & shortlist — Evaluation (phase 5) — In the **Evaluation matrix**, define your **criteria and weights** (Cost, Performance, Risk, Feasibility, Schedule…), then score each alternative **1–5** per criterion. The **weighted score** and **rank** update live; changing a weight re-ranks everything. Shortlist the winners for development.

6. Develop recommendations & the business case (phase 6) — Promote a shortlisted idea with **"Promote to recommendation →"**, then flesh it out — **"✨ Draft with AI"** fills the summary, technical and commercial detail for you to refine. Open the **Business case** and add cost/benefit line items (CAPEX, OPEX, one-off, recurring, benefits); **ROI, payback, NPV and IRR recompute live**. Click **"Save version"** to snapshot it. Finally, capture the **value-handover** items — baselines, KPI definitions and success criteria — that Realization will be measured against. → *Export anytime:* **"Export to Word"** produces a formatted business-case document.

7. Present & get approval — A **Reviewer** signs in, reads the recommendations and business case, and clicks **Accept** or **Reject** on each. Only accepted recommendations can be handed over — this is the governance gate between "proposed value" and "committed work".

→ The handover

8. Hand over to Realization — With at least one **accepted** recommendation, click **"Create Value Realization Track →"**. The platform spins up a linked VR track and **pre-populates it from the study**: work packages (from the accepted recommendations), benefits (from the expected-benefit artifacts), KPI targets, and the baselines/success criteria. The study is marked *handed over* and both sides now show each other's status. → *This is the first-class link.* Open the new track and you'll see "Source study `VE-…`" — click it to jump straight back. Nothing is re-keyed.

🟢 Value Realization — proving the value

9. Intake & baseline (phases 1–2) — The **Realization Manager** opens the track from **Value Realization**. Confirm the objectives and success criteria, and **validate the baselines** carried over from handover. The KPI tracker and benefits list are already seeded — check the data source, frequency and owner on each KPI.

10. Plan implementation & adoption (phases 3–4) — Work the **work packages** (assign owners, set due dates, advance status), and build the **adoption & change plan** — who's impacted, training, comms, champions. This is where recommendations become scheduled, owned work.

11. Execute & track value (phases 5–6) — As delivery happens, advance work-package status and set the track's **health** (green / amber / red). Each period, **record KPI actuals** and update the **realized value** on each benefit — these roll up to the track total and into the portfolio automatically. Capture a **value report / QBR** for stakeholders. → *Export:* **"Export VRP / QBR"** generates the Value Realization Plan and QBR pack as a Word document.

12. Close out & feed back (phase 7) — Confirm **final realized value vs the original business case**, record lessons learned, and route improvements back into the VE templates and playbooks. The loop is closed — you can now point to proven, measured value against the plan you started with.

> **Watch it roll up.** At any point, leaders open the **Portfolio** dashboard to see planned value (from VE studies) against realized value (from VR tracks), broken down by industry and health, plus a **Customer Success lens** (engagement health, upcoming renewals, accounts needing attention) — the whole book of work in one view.

🔷 Customer Success — retaining & growing the relationship

Value Realization proves *one* initiative and then ends; **Customer Success** is the *continuous* relationship layer for the whole account. The **Customer Success Manager** opens **Customer Success**, starts (or imports) an engagement, and works the **8-stage lifecycle**: Handover → Onboarding → Adoption → Value Realisation → Health Management → Governance Rhythm → Renewal → Expansion.

- **It links, it doesn't duplicate.** Attach the account's VE studies and VR tracks — the engagement *surfaces* their planned/realized value; the numbers still live on the tracks (single source of truth).

- **Health Scorecard** — score five weighted factors (adoption, value, sentiment, support, engagement); the overall rolls up to a green/amber/red band shown across the workspace and portfolio.
- **Attention signals** — the engagement and the portfolio flag renewals coming due, red/amber health, overdue actions, detractor stakeholders, and value below plan.
- **Governance artefacts** — a stakeholder map, an action log, and renewal & growth plans. **Generate an EBR narrative** (with Claude, or a template fallback) that also seeds its next-best-actions into the action log; **export an Account Success Review** to Word.

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4 · Everyday features

- **Portfolio dashboard** — leaders' view: active studies & tracks, planned vs realized value, a by-industry rollup, and a Customer Success lens (health + renewals + needs-attention).
- **Customer Success** — per-account engagements: the 8-stage lifecycle, health scorecard, stakeholder map, action log, renewal/growth plans, AI-assisted EBRs, and Account Success Review export.
- **KPI dashboard** — role- and industry-filterable KPIs — VE (alternatives, recs accepted, planned value, avg ROI) and VR (realized value, variance, on-time, reports) — plus the formula catalogue.
- **Template library** — industry profiles, phase-by-phase guidance and reusable starter text for every deliverable.
- **Discussion** — threaded comments on any study or track; delete your own, admins can moderate.
- **Version history** — snapshot the business case with "Save version", review any past version, and restore it if a change regresses.
- **Exports** — business case → Word, Value Realization Plan / QBR → Word, KPI workbook → Excel.
- **AI drafting** — draft recommendation detail and brainstorm alternatives with Claude when a key is set — with a template fallback so it always works.
- **Multi-currency** — ZAR by default, switchable per business case (USD, EUR, GBP, and more); every figure re-formats live.

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5 · Good practice

- **Treat exit criteria as gates.** Don't advance a phase until its checklist is genuinely met — it keeps studies defensible.
- **Spend creative effort where the value index is worst.** High cost-to-worth functions (amber) are where simplification pays off; don't optimise what's already good value.
- **Keep baselines honest.** Realized value is measured against them — a soft baseline flatters the numbers and undermines the QBR.

- **Use the roles as designed.** The engineer builds, a reviewer approves, the manager realizes. Signing in as each shows the same study from three angles.
- **Comment as you go.** Decisions and open questions belong on the study/track, not in email — then a QBR export tells the whole story.
- **Snapshot before big edits.** "Save version" on the business case gives you a safe restore point.

6 · Quick reference

The 8-phase VE Job Plan: 1 Orientation → 2 Information → 3 Function Analysis → 4 Creative → 5 Evaluation → 6 Development → 7 Presentation → 8 Handover.

The 7-phase Realization lifecycle: 1 Intake & Alignment → 2 Baseline & Measurement → 3 Implementation Planning → 4 Adoption & Change → 5 Execution & Monitoring → 6 Value Tracking & Reporting → 7 Close-Out.

Where things live

Screen	Path
Sign in	`/login` — set a demo password when you seed
Portfolio (planned vs realized)	`/portfolio`
VE workspace (studies, "New VE study")	`/ve`
VR workspace (realization tracks)	`/vr`
KPIs (dashboards & catalogue)	`/kpis`
Templates (profiles, guidance, starter text)	`/templates`

> **Turning on AI drafting.** Set `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` in the app's environment and restart. The AI buttons then read "…with AI" and draft with Claude; left unset, they fall back to template starter text and read "…(template)". No other change needed.

See `README.md` for setup and `ARCHITECTURE.md` for the design and data model.